



Antarctica

The continent of Antarctica sits under huge masses of ice called ice sheets. This ice holds 90 per cent of Earth's fresh water. Beneath it lies a continent of valleys, mountains, and lakes but only about 2 per cent is visible above the ice. The only people in Antarctica are scientists and staff working in research stations, and tourists.

EARLY EXPEDITIONS

By the late 19th century, Antarctica remained the last unexplored continent, and the race was on to reach the most remote spot on Earth – the South Pole. In 1909 Ernest Shackleton got within 180 km (111 miles) of the Pole before having to turn back. It was finally reached by explorers Roald Amundsen and Robert Scott in 1911 and 1912.



SHACKLETON'S HOOD



COMPASS, SCOTT'S EXPEDITION



BANJO, SHACKLETON'S EXPEDITION



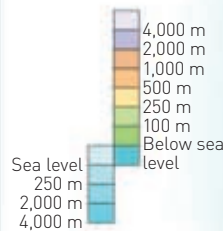
KEY

- Amundsen's route
- Scott's route
- Ice shelves

RACE TO THE POLE

The Norwegian Roald Amundsen beat the Englishman Robert Falcon Scott by 33 days, to reach the South Pole on 15 December 1911.

KEY ELEVATION



- ▲ Mountain
- ▼ Lowest point
- Research station

ICY FEATURES

Antarctica is covered in ice. It has huge masses of glacial ice that are known as ice sheets. Where the ice sheets meet the ocean floating areas of ice form, which are called ice shelves. The edges of these shelves can break away, forming smaller lumps of floating ice called icebergs.



COLLAPSE

Impressive crevasses from the glacier of the melting Larsen B ice shelf, which collapsed in 2002.



ICEBERGS

Immense flat-topped icebergs are formed when blocks of ice break away from the main ice shelf.

